

FPZ Exec Search: Senior Strategy Roles in Creative Agencies and Production Studios

Role landscape

The single most commercially useful signal is that “Chief Strategy Officer” is genuinely a cross-sector senior title, but it behaves like two different products: in creative agencies it is typically a leadership “craft” role for planning, insight and brand/comms strategy, whereas in production studios it is frequently fused with operating mandates (COO, revenue, business operations) and embedded in corporate development, distribution and enterprise strategy. ¹

On the agency side, C-suite and near-C-suite strategy titles in active use include Global Chief Strategy Officer at Ogilvy (Mick McCabe) and at dentsu international (Alex Hesz), Chief Strategy Officer at AKQA (Miriam Plon Sauer), Chief Strategy Officer at Wieden+Kennedy New York (Laura Rowan), Chief Strategy Officer at Dentsu UK & Ireland (Dan Truman), Chief Strategy Officer at Spark Foundry UK (Venya Wijegoonewardene), Chief Strategy Officer at VML UK (Ben Worden), Chief Strategy Officer at Havas Lynx UK (Ayesha Walawalkar), and Global Chief Strategy Officer, Marketing at Accenture Song (Ariana Stolarz). ² These are structurally consistent with agency strategy being a distinct discipline that leads teams of “brand/comms/social/data” strategists (explicitly stated in the Wieden+Kennedy New York CSO appointment) and is tied to client growth and effectiveness (explicitly framed in multiple agency announcements). ³

On the studio side, “strategy” at the top end often appears as a corporate power-centre rather than a pure planning craft. Current examples include Chief Strategy Officer and Chief Operating Officer at Paramount (Andy Gordon), Chief Revenue and Strategy Officer at Warner Bros. Discovery (Bruce Campbell), and Executive Vice President, Chief Strategy Officer and Business Operations at Sony Pictures Entertainment (Jay Levine). ⁴ The remit descriptions are telling: Warner Bros. Discovery explicitly rolls corporate development and strategy, distribution revenue and content licensing, and streaming platform agreements into the Chief Revenue and Strategy Officer role; Sony Pictures explicitly couples “Chief Strategy Officer” with “Business Operations.” ⁵ In UK production, ITV lists a Management Board role titled Director of Strategy, Policy and Regulation (Magnus Brooke) with explicit responsibility for corporate strategy development, while STV Studios appointed a Chief Financial Officer & Strategy Director (Colin Waters). ⁶

At Director and VP levels, agency and studio titles diverge even more. Agencies commonly use titles like Strategy Director (for example, Droga5’s Strategy Director role, and Ogilvy UK’s Strategy Director postings) and EVP/VP variants that are discipline-shaped, such as VP, Medical Strategy at Ogilvy Health; these jobs are phrased around leading account strategy, strategic product quality, and partnering with creative and client teams. ⁷ Studios, by contrast, use Director, Strategy and Insights at Paramount Pictures (reporting into an SVP of Global Strategy and Insights, covering a film slate) and VP, Studio Franchise Strategy at Paramount (explicitly centred on long-term business and revenue strategies for franchises, executive presentations, and cross-company coordination). ⁸ A further studio pattern is that strategy leadership can live under finance/corporate strategy: Paramount’s Senior Vice President, Corporate Strategy role is described as part of the Finance organisation supporting the CEO, CFO, CSO, SLT and Board on company strategy. ⁹

Where titles are multiplying versus consolidating, the cleanest evidence is in appointment patterns and job-title “bundling”. “Chief Strategy Officer” appears to be multiplying across agency ecosystems at group, network, and operating-company level, including new or newly emphasised CSO appointments at Spark Foundry UK (2024), Dentsu UK&I (first-ever CSO, 2024), AKQA (CSO appointed in the wake of a new global structure, 2024/25), and laterally in large-agency moves such as Wieden+Kennedy New York’s CSO hire. ¹⁰ The reverse trend, consolidation, is most visible in studios and studio-adjacent organisations where strategy is increasingly fused with COO, revenue, finance or business operations (Paramount CSO & COO; WBD Chief Revenue and Strategy Officer; Sony EVP, CSO and Business Operations; STV CFO & Strategy Director). ¹¹ That same consolidation pressure is now also observable inside agencies as titles like “Chief Strategy and Innovation Officer” get folded back into a narrower CSO remit and/or moved into general management: Spark Foundry UK explicitly states the incoming Chief Strategy Officer will take over responsibilities previously held by a Chief Strategy and Innovation Officer who moved into a co-managing director role. ¹²

AI intersection

The single most commercially useful AI finding is that AI has already created net-new senior strategy leadership roles in both agencies and studios, with multiple “first/inaugural” Chief AI Officer appointments since 2024 and a parallel rise of “Head of AI Strategy” titles inside agencies, implying a fresh, less relationship-locked search corridor compared with legacy planning leadership. ¹³

For the established Chief Strategy Officer title in agencies, AI is reshaping expectations, but unevenly and often implicitly rather than as a formal title change. A direct example is the public comment from Javier Santana, Chief Strategy Officer at Chemistry, that “AI fluency is an expectation,” signalling a baseline shift in strategic leadership credibility and talent evaluation inside agencies. ¹⁴ A second, more structural indicator is that AKQA’s post-structure-change leadership slate pairs the appointment of a Chief Strategy Officer (Miriam Plon Sauer) with explicit AI-driven transformation language in adjacent C-suite roles such as Chief Technology Officer (a former Google AI leader) and Chief Transformation Officer, framed around integrating “digital and AI-driven innovation” and “emerging technologies” into business models. This is not a renamed CSO role, but it does suggest that agency strategy leaders are now expected to operate alongside, and frequently co-own, AI-enabled transformation narratives. ¹⁵

For studio CSO and corporate strategy leadership, AI is showing up as operationalised capability rather than primarily as a “thought leadership” requirement. Paramount’s Director, Strategy and Insights posting explicitly lists “advancing AI use in research” as part of implementing innovative approaches across the studio’s strategy and insights work, alongside expanded analysis and competitive evaluation. ¹⁶ Meanwhile, Paramount’s Senior Vice President, Corporate Strategy description explicitly includes coordination of activity in “areas of emerging technology such as NFTs,” which is not AI, but it is direct evidence that “strategy” functions in studios are being tasked with active scanning and internal coordination around fast-moving technology themes. ⁹

AI is also driving the emergence of hybrid “strategy + commercial mandate” roles in agency-land, which matters because it changes who owns budgets and therefore who can sponsor retained search. Monks publicly references a Chief AI & Revenue Officer (Wesley ter Haar) and has also added EVP, AI innovation (Dave Meeker), signalling an AI leadership layer that is directly coupled to commercial outcomes and not just experimentation. ¹⁷ In holding-company structures adjacent to agency networks, Interpublic Group (IPG) created the titled role Global Head of AI Commerce (Yaniv Sarig), described as reinforcing the company’s commitment to AI-driven commerce solutions, and Stagwell appointed an “inaugural” Chief AI Officer (John Kahan) to spearhead AI integration across its global network. ¹⁸

Where AI has clearly created net-new senior strategy roles that did not exist pre-2023, the best evidenced cluster is Chief AI Officer (and close variants) in both agencies and studios. On the agency side, Luckie & Co. announced an appointment to Chief AI Officer (2024), INVNT announced its first Global Chief AI Officer (2025), and Publicis Connected Media France announced a Chief AI Officer with an explicit mission to define, structure and pilot “agentic and generative AI strategy” and related governance and talent acculturation. ¹⁹ On the studio side, Lionsgate appointed its first Chief AI Officer (Kathleen Grace) to lead the studio’s generative AI strategy for filmmaking, which is a direct example of AI becoming a board-level strategic function in a film and TV studio context rather than a departmental capability. ²⁰ More broadly, industry reporting has framed Chief AI Officer as a “new addition” to senior officer classes, suggesting the role category itself is still in expansion mode rather than mature consolidation. ²¹

At Director and VP levels, AI’s impact is mixed and therefore commercially important for FPZ to segment. Some strategy director roles still read as essentially “classic craft” with no explicit AI or genAI requirement in the public-facing job narrative (for example, the Droga5 Strategy Director description centres on account strategy leadership and strategic product quality without referencing AI). ²² Conversely, some studio strategy roles now embed AI directly into the work (Paramount’s Director, Strategy and Insights explicitly does), and some agency CSO roles are now being publicly positioned as “creative + technology” leadership: a profile of Baiju Shah’s time as Global Chief Strategy Officer at Accenture Song describes him leading growth strategy and “creating what’s next in creativity and technology using innovations like generative artificial intelligence.” ²³

Compensation and fee potential

The single most commercially useful compensation point is that, on base salary alone, the US materially outperforms the UK for exec search fee upside: a US Chief Strategy Officer typical base range implies roughly \$83k–\$153k fees at 25% and \$110k–\$203k at 33%, while a UK Chief Strategy Officer typical base range implies roughly £24k–£65k at 25% and £31k–£86k at 33%. ²⁴

Publicly available compensation data does not reliably segment “Strategy Director / VP Strategy / CSO” pay between creative agencies versus production studios as a category; where this research uses job-posted ranges (Paramount examples) the numbers are studio-specific, and where it uses aggregated market data (Glassdoor; Morgan McKinley) the numbers reflect cross-industry reporting for the title and location. ²⁵

Level and representative title	Geography	Base salary range evidenced in sources	Fee at 25% of base	Fee at 33% of base	Source used for the range
Director level (Strategy Director, London benchmark)	UK	£105,000–£160,000	£26,250–£40,000	£34,650–£52,800	Morgan McKinley salary calculator (London, 2026). ²⁶
VP level (Vice President Strategy, UK typical range)	UK	£103,956–£189,365	£25,989–£47,341	£34,305–£62,490	Glassdoor (UK, March 2026; typical range shown as 25th–75th percentiles). ²⁷

Level and representative title	Geography	Base salary range evidenced in sources	Fee at 25% of base	Fee at 33% of base	Source used for the range
C-suite level (Chief Strategy Officer, UK typical range)	UK	£94,280–£261,466	£23,570–£65,367	£31,112–£86,284	Glassdoor (UK, March 2026; typical range shown as 25th–75th percentiles). ²⁸
Director level (Director, Strategy and Insights, Paramount Pictures)	US	\$120,000–\$155,000	\$30,000–\$38,750	\$39,600–\$51,150	Paramount job posting hiring salary range. ²⁹
VP level (VP, Studio Franchise Strategy, Paramount+)	US	\$205,000–\$254,000	\$51,250–\$63,500	\$67,650–\$83,820	ShowbizJobs listing with published hiring salary range for the role. ³⁰
C-suite level (Chief Strategy Officer, US typical range)	US	\$332,524–\$613,772	\$83,131–\$153,443	\$109,733–\$202,545	Glassdoor (US, March 2026; typical range shown as 25th–75th percentiles). ³¹

Across the ranges above, the fee floor (lowest observed 25% fee on base in-scope) is approximately £23,570 (UK CSO, 25% of the 25th percentile), while the fee ceiling (highest observed 33% fee on base in-scope) is approximately \$202,545 (US CSO, 33% of the 75th percentile).³² The UK/US differential is most pronounced at C-suite, but it also shows up in studio-specific VP strategy roles where posted hiring ranges at Paramount imply \$51k–\$64k fees at 25% for VP-level franchise strategy, which is a materially larger “mid-tier” fee outcome than many UK Director-level outcomes even in London.³³

Search viability

The single most commercially useful viability fact is that retained executive search is demonstrably in play around senior strategy hiring in these sectors, because a specialist agency-focused executive search firm explicitly serves “Agencies” and “Sports & Entertainment” and lists strategy and production among its disciplinary coverage, while a top-tier retained firm reports conducting more than 2,400 senior-level executive searches and board appointments for global media and entertainment companies over five years.³⁴

Evidence that organisations can and do use search is strongest at the studio and media end of the spectrum, where leadership and corporate strategy are tightly tied to corporate development, distribution and shareholder-facing narratives. Spencer Stuart frames its media offering around executive search and board work at scale, and the role shapes described in Warner Bros. Discovery’s “Chief Revenue and Strategy Officer” remit map cleanly onto the kind of cross-enterprise mandate

where retained search is commonly used to ensure discretion and breadth of candidate access. ³⁵ At the agency end, the existence of specialist search firms is unambiguous, but the use of search versus network is harder to prove from public reporting because most “people move” announcements do not disclose whether a search partner was involved (for example, CSO appointments at Ogilvy and AKQA are announced without naming a search firm, and Sony’s CSO appointment announcement similarly does not name a search partner). ³⁶ That means FourPointZero should assume that a meaningful portion of top strategy placements are still relationship-led, particularly for agencies where the CSO is a high-visibility cultural leader, but also recognise that retained search is a normal buying behaviour in adjacent leadership categories, and therefore is winnable with the right wedge. ³⁷

On retained versus contingent, the cleanest defensible statement is that the mainstream “executive search” segment is explicitly positioned as retained by major firms, and specialist firms in the advertising/agency ecosystem are described as retained search businesses in corporate reporting. Heidrick & Struggles describes itself as a “leading retained search firm,” and industry coverage of Sinecure’s 2024 acquisition of Grace Blue describes Grace Blue as a retained search firm. ³⁸ Korn Ferry’s own executive search positioning also frames executive search as a specialist approach that organisations “retain” for confidential, hard-to-reach senior leaders (which aligns with CSO/CAIO dynamics in both agencies and studios). ³⁹

Firms already visibly operating in (or adjacent to) this territory include Grace Blue (explicit agency and sports/entertainment practices; discipline coverage includes strategy and production), Spencer Stuart (media and entertainment executive search), and the large retained platforms that sell exec search and leadership advisory into these industries, including Heidrick & Struggles, Korn Ferry and Russell Reynolds Associates. ⁴⁰ In AI-adjacent strategy leadership, the competitive set broadens further because holding companies and studios are now creating “first/inaugural” AI officer roles, which are classic retained-search triggers due to novelty, risk and board scrutiny (for example, Stagwell’s inaugural Chief AI Officer; Lionsgate’s first Chief AI Officer; and Publicis Connected Media France’s Chief AI Officer). ⁴¹

Overall search viability: High, because the roles sit at the intersection of growth, technology change and enterprise risk, the US fee math is strong, and retained search activity is provably present in the agency and media/entertainment ecosystem, even though individual appointment announcements often conceal the search channel. ⁴²

Senior strategy roles look like a viable expansion for FourPointZero’s exec search scope, but only if you treat “agency strategy” and “studio strategy” as separate capability markets with different candidate pedigrees and buying behaviours: the strongest entry point is AI-led strategy leadership (Chief AI Officer, Head of AI Strategy, Chief AI & Revenue Officer, EVP AI innovation) because these roles are demonstrably net-new since 2024–2026, carry transformation urgency, and are less likely to be filled purely by legacy planning networks than a classic agency CSO, while still laddering into high-fee CSO and corporate strategy searches once credibility is established. ⁴³

¹ ² ³⁶ <https://www.ogilvy.com/ideas/ogilvy-names-mick-mccabe-global-chief-strategy-officer>
<https://www.ogilvy.com/ideas/ogilvy-names-mick-mccabe-global-chief-strategy-officer>

³ <https://www.lbbonline.com/news/laura-rowan-joins-wiedenkenndy-new-york-as-chief-strategy-officer>
<https://www.lbbonline.com/news/laura-rowan-joins-wiedenkenndy-new-york-as-chief-strategy-officer>

⁴ ¹¹ <https://www.paramount.com/about/leadership>
<https://www.paramount.com/about/leadership>

- 5 <https://www.wbd.com/leadership/bruce-campbell/>
<https://www.wbd.com/leadership/bruce-campbell/>
- 6 <https://www.itvplc.com/about-itv/group-executive-committee>
<https://www.itvplc.com/about-itv/group-executive-committee>
- 7 22 <https://jobs.managementconsulted.com/jobs/266100096-droga5-strategy-director>
<https://jobs.managementconsulted.com/jobs/266100096-droga5-strategy-director>
- 8 16 25 29 <https://careers.paramount.com/job/Los-Angeles-Director%2C-Strategy-and-Insights%2C-Paramount-Pictures-CA-90038/1343605500/>
<https://careers.paramount.com/job/Los-Angeles-Director%2C-Strategy-and-Insights%2C-Paramount-Pictures-CA-90038/1343605500/>
- 9 <https://www.showbizjobs.com/jobs/paramount-senior-vice-president-corporate-strategy-in-new-york/jid-gq9j79>
<https://www.showbizjobs.com/jobs/paramount-senior-vice-president-corporate-strategy-in-new-york/jid-gq9j79>
- 10 12 <https://www.publicisgroupeuk.com/news-and-views/news/spark-foundry-uk-hires-chief-strategy-officer/>
<https://www.publicisgroupeuk.com/news-and-views/news/spark-foundry-uk-hires-chief-strategy-officer/>
- 13 19 43 <https://www.prnewswire.com/news-releases/luckie-appoints-chief-ai-officer-302303239.html>
<https://www.prnewswire.com/news-releases/luckie-appoints-chief-ai-officer-302303239.html>
- 14 <https://newthorpeservices.com/generative-ai-is-altering-the-agency-junior-talent-search/>
<https://newthorpeservices.com/generative-ai-is-altering-the-agency-junior-talent-search/>
- 15 <https://www.akqa.com/news/akqa-strengthens-global-leadership-to-drive-next-chapter-of-growth/>
<https://www.akqa.com/news/akqa-strengthens-global-leadership-to-drive-next-chapter-of-growth/>
- 17 <https://www.monks.com/wesleybot>
<https://www.monks.com/wesleybot>
- 18 <https://markets.ft.com/data/announce/detail?dockey=1330-9419532en-1N69UCKJBFE2PERSB50QD8325V>
<https://markets.ft.com/data/announce/detail?dockey=1330-9419532en-1N69UCKJBFE2PERSB50QD8325V>
- 20 <https://uk.news.yahoo.com/lionsgate-hires-chief-ai-officer-213000799.html>
<https://uk.news.yahoo.com/lionsgate-hires-chief-ai-officer-213000799.html>
- 21 <https://zefr.com/press/why-brands-and-agencies-are-putting-ai-chiefs-in-their-c-suites>
<https://zefr.com/press/why-brands-and-agencies-are-putting-ai-chiefs-in-their-c-suites>
- 23 <https://design.northwestern.edu/mmm-program/inside-our-program/stories/2024/an-insiders-perspective-on-growth-innovation.html>
<https://design.northwestern.edu/mmm-program/inside-our-program/stories/2024/an-insiders-perspective-on-growth-innovation.html>
- 24 31 https://www.glassdoor.com/Salaries/chief-strategy-officer-salary-SRCH_KO0%2C22.htm
https://www.glassdoor.com/Salaries/chief-strategy-officer-salary-SRCH_KO0%2C22.htm
- 26 <https://www.morganmckinley.com/uk/salary-guide/data/strategy-director/london>
<https://www.morganmckinley.com/uk/salary-guide/data/strategy-director/london>
- 27 https://www.glassdoor.co.uk/Salaries/vice-president-strategy-salary-SRCH_KO0%2C23.htm
https://www.glassdoor.co.uk/Salaries/vice-president-strategy-salary-SRCH_KO0%2C23.htm
- 28 32 https://www.glassdoor.co.uk/Salaries/chief-strategy-officer-salary-SRCH_IN2_KO0%2C22.htm
https://www.glassdoor.co.uk/Salaries/chief-strategy-officer-salary-SRCH_IN2_KO0%2C22.htm

30 33 <https://www.showbizjobs.com/jobs/paramount--vice-president-studio-franchise-strategy-in-los-angeles/jid-g4bbm7>

<https://www.showbizjobs.com/jobs/paramount--vice-president-studio-franchise-strategy-in-los-angeles/jid-g4bbm7>

34 40 <https://graceblue.com/>

<https://graceblue.com/>

35 42 <https://www.spencerstuart.com/what-we-do/industries-we-serve/technology-media-telecom/media>

<https://www.spencerstuart.com/what-we-do/industries-we-serve/technology-media-telecom/media>

37 39 <https://www.kornferry.com/uk/capabilities/talent-acquisition/executive-search>

<https://www.kornferry.com/uk/capabilities/talent-acquisition/executive-search>

38 <https://www.heidrick.com/en/>

<https://www.heidrick.com/en/>

41 <https://www.stagwellglobal.com/stagwell-stgw-appoints-john-kahan-as-inaugural-chief-ai-officer/>

<https://www.stagwellglobal.com/stagwell-stgw-appoints-john-kahan-as-inaugural-chief-ai-officer/>